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The sun set slowly in summer, taking its time in a languid descent towards the horizon. It was observed by one soul in the area behind the row of shops by an otter slouched over the balcony railings, tail flicking idly as he mused. Of course, Liam knew the sun did not descend in that manner: everyone knew that. Or, at least, he hoped everyone knew that. It would be quite concerning to discover that someone of a knowledgeable age . He knew a lot more than that fact but kept the knowledge to himself. Rarely did he find opportunity to share.

On the other paw, he wished that he had something more interesting to do than stand on the balcony of his flat – a four room closet set above a chip shop, the smell of which permeated every inch of the abode – and muse over the red sunset. Casting his eyes over his optimally bleak surroundings, the cluster of cars in the car park and old newspaper scudding across the tarmac, he wished not for the first time that he had a little more than one or two pennies in his pocket. His flat left much to be desired in the peeling paint on the railing and creaky front door, swinging in the breeze. He had managed to set out on his own some eight months ago and was finding that he liked it less and less. The only bonus of the flat was its location beside his workplace: Solihull ice rink.

Liam tugged at the collar of his faded, blue t-shirt, making a mental note to allocate some funds to a couple of new shirts, though they would have to be an eBay job once again. Who would know? Seagulls swooped above, screeching obnoxiously as their reflections flitted in and out of sight on the flat windows, swooping and searching for any leftovers that may have once been edible, or not. Sighing heavily as if the weight of the world rested upon his narrow shoulders, Liam propped his muzzle on his paw and looked down over the railings, noting the small drop without thinking: enough to injure, not enough to conclude.

Under normal circumstances, he would be at the ice rink at this time on a Saturday evening. Working on the maintenance, cafe, ticket sales – he did it all, really – gave him some leeway when it came to skating time. As long as he was not working or was on a lunch break, he was allowed use of the rink during public sessions and sometimes even between sessions or after hours, which was an admittedly sweet deal for any skating enthusiast. Skating was something that he had sorely missed during his final few years of living in Wales and one of the chief reasons that he had moved away – nothing remained to tie him to his home. Back in Cardiff, he had skated at the local rink until it had been torn down for complete refurbishment and then remained boarded up for years afterwards, leading him to false hope again and again. His sister told him that it had been reopened after he had moved away but he could find little reason to rejoice in that and wondered why she found it so important to mention.

For a few months after starting his job at the ice rink, there had been a slot between booked Saturday evening sessions where the otter could make use of the rink for an hour or more, if he was lucky, though that slot had now been filled. It was annoying yet expected as he did not have jurisdiction over who used the rink at what time, though the lack of a slot was the main reason for his balcony waiting. Bored without his usual pastime, he paced or stood upon his balcony every Saturday evening until the neighbouring ice hockey team practicing within emerged in a raucous flash of activity. They came out in groups of varying numbers and Liam counted every one until he was sure the rink was empty of anyone but another on maintenance – normally the scowling fox, Kyle, who seemed to have a kind of affinity with the ice hockey team. Kyle always ensured he was working Saturday evenings, which Liam was thankful for, much to his embarrassment.

Truth be told to no one but himself, he found the neighbouring team intimidating.

If it had been the figure skaters – easily charmed – the otter would not have lacked courage, or so he told himself. In fact, this note was evidenced by how he hung around the rink during figure skating practices, not for any personal interest in the display but to steal more ice time wherever possible. The coaches all knew him anyway. Shuddering, Liam curled one paw around his bicep, recalling a very different experience with the resident ice hockey team, staple in their consistency of players and well established. The first time he had tried to slink on to the ice after they had played – the goals and pucks had all been tidied away by Kyle as opposed to the team – they had shoved past him, sending the comparatively petite otter skidding against the seats at the side of the rink, leaving his body smarting and pride bruised. It was not difficult to be smaller when faced with all the gear the players had to wear and the general stature of those on this particular team. Perhaps the pushing by different members had been because they had been keen to get on the ice but the experience sullied his view of them nonetheless and they always demanded increased time or higher rates whenever he had the misfortune to be scheduled to work while they were practicing or, god forbid, playing a game. Last time, an ambulance had to be called for one of the players on the opposing team.

Not that Liam was a stranger to ice hockey or not a fan, but he knew the difference between a genuinely aggressive fur and one that played by the rules of the sport. The Solihull team had more than one underhand trick up their sleeves and had gotten away with more than Liam could immediately bring to mind.

He sighed, shaking his head. A piece of black paint flaked